

ASSESSMENT AND GRADING

This policy and accompanying Regulation 5030 are based on the belief that assessment of student learning is an essential component of the teaching and learning process and has the potential to motivate students and improve learning. This policy also seeks to establish a consistent approach to assessment and grading while promoting high expectations in all Loudoun County Public Schools.

A. Philosophy of Assessment and Grading. Assessment and grading of student progress are based on the premise that students have diverse capabilities and individual patterns of progress and learning. Teachers and principals are responsible for developing instructional plans based on frequent and varied assessments of the students' needs, abilities, and progress. Though the primary outcome of grading and assessment is a reflection of mastery, it also reflects a student's motivation and work ethic towards that outcome. Grades shall not reflect a student's behavior in the classroom. Assessment and grading activities should:

1. Communicate academic achievement and social-emotional growth on a regular basis to students and parents.
2. Reflect individual differences and rates of learning.
3. Address the unique needs of special population students including, but not limited to, gifted learners, English Learners (EL), and students with disabilities.
4. Ensure Individualized Education Plan (IEP) and 504 Plan accommodations are applied to assessment and grading.
5. Make adjustments for transitional periods in students' lives, including elementary school to middle school and middle school to high school.
6. Reflect expectations for student learning.
7. Provide for student self-evaluation.
8. Encourage students to take an active role in setting goals and assessing progress toward an identifiable and measurable set of standards that are in alignment with the stated learning objectives.
9. Foster student reflection, agency, and ownership through a growth mindset toward learning.

ASSESSMENT AND GRADING

10. Inform all participants about the purpose, philosophy, and procedures of the grading and reporting system.
11. Be aligned with a school-wide system of interventions and supports for teachers and students.
12. Ensure grades reflect student learning through multiple efforts which include reassessment opportunities and student growth within a grade level or subject.
13. Ensure Dual Enrollment (DE) courses in high schools meet their unique grading and withdrawal policies as specified by the accrediting college or university.
14. Promote consistency and predictability in grading and assessment through instructional staff adhering to common grading expectations set forth in Regulation 5030.

B. Definitions for Grades K-12.

1. Assessment. Assessment is the process of identifying the extent of learning that has occurred during or after the learning process. It determines whether the learner has reached the target objective(s). It measures the degree of mastery of content or competencies. Assessment is used to inform next steps in teaching and learning. Assessments may be formative or summative.
2. Grading. Grading is the process of assigning value to a student's mastery of content or competencies. Grades communicate a measure of a student's mastery of content or competencies as compared to state standards and local curricula.
3. Formative Assessment. Formative assessment occurs during the learning process and is designed to guide next steps toward mastery. The goal of formative assessment is to monitor learning, provide feedback, and set goals to move learning forward. Information gathered during the formative assessment is used to inform the next steps in instruction and to help students evaluate and set goals for their own progress. Completion of all formative assessments and homework assignments throughout the quarter may be applied to no more than 10% (to include completion and reasonable effort when appropriate) of the quarter grade.

ASSESSMENT AND GRADING

4. Homework. Homework is a natural extension of the school day and can be practice for reinforcement and application of previously learned concepts. Any homework that is assigned must be something the students are able to complete successfully on their own in a reasonable amount of time. Given that homework is considered practice and/or application with an opportunity for feedback, it is considered a formative assessment.

5. Reasonable Effort. Reasonable effort occurs when a student submits an assignment, formative assessment, or summative assessment in which they have made an attempt to complete it using the information provided during instruction.

6. Summative Assessment. Summative assessment occurs at the end of a learning cycle and is designed to determine a student's level of mastery of specified content or competencies. A major summative assessment is between 10% and 25% of the quarter grade. Summative assessments less than 10% of the quarter grade are considered minor summative assessments.

C. Elementary Grading Procedures. The Elementary Report Card Manual describes grading procedures for grades K-5. Students in grades K-2 are assessed using progress indicators based on their performance in relation to specific state standards. In grades 3-5, students receive more traditional letter grades in addition to the progress indicators based on performance tied to each standard. Elementary teachers look for trends in each student's performance instead of averaging numerical scores to determine a grade.

D. Secondary Grading Procedures. Students in grades 6-12 are assessed using letter and/or numeric grades based on their performance in relation to specific state standards. Students receive grades that are averaged into a numerical score to determine a letter grade that is reported at the end of each quarter. The semester grade for a student is calculated by averaging the two quarter grades within that semester. A student's final grade is calculated by averaging the two semester grades.

E. Best Practices in K-12 Assessment and Grading. Best practices for assessment and grading in LCPS are outlined in Regulation 5030.

1. Homework. Teachers should generally consider homework as practice and/or application with an opportunity for feedback and, therefore, is considered a formative assessment. Middle and high school teachers may assign reports and projects that are completed outside of the classroom. These may be considered major summative assessments and may count between 10% and 25% of the quarter grade.

ASSESSMENT AND GRADING

2. Formative Assessment. Formative assessments may be administered to monitor learning, provide feedback, and set goals to move learning forward. Information gathered by teachers during the formative assessment can be used to inform next steps in instruction. The cumulative completion of all formative assessments and homework assignments may be applied to no more than 10% (to include completion and reasonable effort when appropriate) of the quarter grade.

3. Summative Assessment. Summative assessments may be administered in courses to evaluate student learning, skill attainment, and achievement at the conclusion of a defined instructional period, typically at the end of a unit, course, semester, program, or school year.

- a. Grade level and subject area teams should establish common, standardized major summative assessments. Teams should create rigorous and authentic opportunities for students to demonstrate and apply their learning in various ways.
- b. There are no formal midterm or final exam grades.
- c. An individual major summative assessment will be limited to no more than 25% of the quarter grade. Each major summative assessment will have at least one opportunity for a formative assessment prior to it.

4. Floor of 50%. An assessment and grading system must be designed to motivate students and promote reasonable effort towards a growth mindset. Students who receive a grade below 50% often feel they have no chance of recovery and give up on achieving success in a course. To address this, LCPS supports a minimum grade of 50% for quarter grades and final grades for students who have demonstrated a reasonable effort throughout the quarter. In high school courses, the floor of 50% does not apply to AP classes or the final quarter of a course.

5. Reassessment. Reassessment encourages a growth mindset in students and allows them to demonstrate mastery. Teachers will provide opportunity for reassessment of only major summative assessments to students who scored below 70% and have demonstrated reasonable effort to complete all homework and formative assessments prior to the initial assessment.

- a. Remediation or reteaching of certain concepts may be required prior to reassessment. The teacher should provide the opportunity for reassessment within two weeks' time whenever possible and

ASSESSMENT AND GRADING

give clear communication on when those opportunities are reasonably available (i.e., time, dates, and location). The student should make the effort to coordinate with the teacher to schedule any reassessment. The student will be given the higher grade between the original assessment and the reassessment, up to 70%.

- b. Reassessments for major summative assessments will be available for students who have demonstrated a reasonable effort on homework and formative assessments. When multiple reassessments are requested by a student, teachers, in consultation with student support teams (e.g., teacher, school counselor, etc.) and parents, may limit future opportunities for reassessment.

6. Late Work. Teachers should accept late work to document learning and inform instruction prior to the administration of a major summative assessment. Reasonable and consistent guidelines for accepting late work must be set and communicated to students.

- a. Deadlines should be required for submitting late work.
- b. Late work will not be accepted after the major summative assessment that is associated with the work has been administered.

7. Grade Level Expectations. There may be variances on how this policy is applied between the elementary, middle, and high school levels. This variance is outlined in regulation and Division grading and assessment handbooks.

8. Exceptions. Dual enrollment grading and assessment must align with the grading policies specified by the accrediting college or university.

9. Extra Credit. Extra credit may be permitted if connected to course content and cumulatively does not exceed 3% of the quarter grade. Extra credit must be available to all students when it is offered.

ASSESSMENT AND GRADING

F. Academic Integrity. Students are expected to perform honestly on all schoolwork and assessments. Any student who turns in work that is not their own, regardless of the source or who assists, or gives their work to another student will receive a consequence aligned with the LCPS disciplinary guidelines as described in the Student Rights and Responsibilities Guide and LCPS Policy 8215, In-School Disciplinary Measures.

If dishonesty is determined, students must complete an alternative summative assessment to demonstrate learning. An academic recovery plan will be created for the assessed content standards and competencies involving any of the following parties: counselor, administrator, teacher, parent, and student. Any academic recovery plan may include a parent-teacher conference, retaking the assessment, an alternative assessment, a lowering of the grade, or receiving a failing grade.

1. The following actions are prohibited:
 - a. Cheating on an assessment or assigned work by giving, receiving, offering and/or soliciting information.
 - b. Plagiarizing by copying the language, structure, idea, and/or thoughts of another.
 - c. Falsifying statements on any assigned schoolwork, tests, or other school documents.
 - d. Knowingly utilizing generative artificial intelligence (AI) on an assignment unless directed to do so by the teacher or as a documented accommodation or assistive technology in a student's Section 504 Plan or IEP.
2. Teachers should take the following actions:
 - a. Clearly define expectations regarding dishonesty in assigned work.
 - b. Reinforce behavioral expectations regarding dishonesty in assigned work.
 - c. Provide feedback throughout the learning process or the assignment timeline.
 - d. Take reasonable actions to maintain assessment and test security.

ASSESSMENT AND GRADING

G. Grading Scales for Middle and High School Students. Since grades are reported in order to communicate student performance, it is important that a standard system be used. All grades given to middle and high school students will reflect the alphabetic and numeric values indicated below, and this scale is to be used in reporting grades on report cards and other scholastic records.

The LCPS Grading Scale is below:

A+ = 98 – 100 A = 93 – 97 A- = 90 – 92	An “A” generally designates the status of a student who consistently demonstrates accurate and complete knowledge of content and competencies specified in the course curriculum and applies that knowledge in a variety of settings.
B+ = 87 – 89 B = 83 – 86 B- = 80 – 82	A “B” generally designates the status of a student who demonstrates knowledge of content and competencies specified in the course curriculum with some improvement needed in accuracy and/or consistency in performance and applying that knowledge in a variety of settings.
C+ = 77 – 79 C = 73 – 76 C- = 70 – 72	A “C” generally designates the status of a student who demonstrates knowledge of basic content and competencies specified in the course curriculum but requires additional practice and instructional experiences to acquire skills necessary to apply that knowledge in a variety of settings.
D+ = 67 – 69 D = 63 – 66 D- = 60 – 62	A “D” generally designates the status of a student who needs significant practice and instructional interventions to acquire the knowledge of basic content and competencies specified in the course curriculum necessary to apply that knowledge in a variety of settings.

ASSESSMENT AND GRADING

F = 59 or lower	An “F” generally designates the status of a student who has not demonstrated the basic knowledge of content and/or competencies specified in the course curriculum and requires additional practice and instructional interventions in order to succeed.
-----------------	--

[Former Policies, 5-5, 5-14, and 5-21]

Adopted: 12/10/85

Revised: 6/22/93, 6/12/01, 9/22/09, 10/22/19, 9/22/20, 11/4/20, 9/14/21

Current Revision: 4/08/25

Reference: Policy [8215](#), In-School Disciplinary Measures, Student Rights and Responsibilities